

"Locate bus stops where pedestrians can cross the road safely and reduce pedestrian wait time to 50 seconds."

GEETAM TIWARI, Associate Professor, IIT Delhi



SAFER STREETS

- Speed checks help as pedestrians have a 90 per cent chance of surviving a car accident when hit at speeds below 45 kmph
- Random breath testing can reduce alcohol-related crashes by up to 20 per cent
- Wearing a helmet correctly can reduce the risk of death by 40 per cent and the risk of severe injuries by 70 per cent
- Wearing seat belts reduces the risk of fatality among front seat passengers by almost 40-50 per cent, and among back seat passengers by 25-75 per cent
- The mandatory use of child restraints can reduce child deaths by 35 per cent

Source GSRRS

we are very apathetic to a fellow road user's pain."

The fact is that there are too many vehicles on our roads which are built without any foresight or care for future projection of traffic volumes. The Indian capital alone adds nearly 1,000 cars every day to the existing traffic. Vehicular traffic in India is growing at the rate of 10 per cent per year and still the government and local agencies responsible for road safety and traffic management have been dangerously tardy in their response. The National Road Safety and Traffic Management Board recommended by the Sundar Committee way back in 2004 was only created last week and will take many more weeks, if not years, to get down to business. The Central Government's position has been that the safety of road users is primarily the responsibility of the concerned state governments, which, being resource-hungry, treat road safety as a low priority area.

A conference—Road Safety Investments in India—organised last year by the Institute of Road Traffic Education and the Commission for Global Road Safety made specific rec-

40

PER CENT IS THE REDUCTION IN DEATHS FOR TWO-WHEELER RIDERS THAT WEARING CRASH HELMETS WILL ENSURE.

Gurgaon expressway trying to avoid a pedestrian who was running across the road in March this year. No help arrived for the next 45 minutes by which time it was too late. Says his distraught father K.S. Anand: "Had they provided for a safe passage to pedestrians and emergency ambulance services my son would have been alive." He has sued the NHAI and the expressway operator. Adds M.C Misra, chief of the Trauma Centre at AIIMS: "Fatality figures can be reduced substantially if victims are given correct first-aid and rushed to the hospital as soon as possible." He mentions road accident victims who have been brought to the trauma centre nine hours after the accident. Even the capital has only 35 ambulances earmarked for road accidents.

There is also the fact that most Indians are reluctant to get involved in a road accident case either because it make them a witness in a police case or because the mental makeup is not wired to helping strangers. Says Subroto Roy, founder of Lifeline, an ambulance service: "While prevention of accidents is of paramount importance, the safety of the victim after an accident has occurred is equally important but often a neglected part of motor vehicle issues. It has never been given the importance of being a multi-stakeholder activity in India." He adds: "Moreover, road safety, like any other safety issue, is not a priority in India. We do not have structured good Samaritan laws that bind the psyche of Indians to intervene in a road traffic accident. Worse still,

ommendations about the political prioritisation of road safety in India, implementation of a single road safety administration, investment of 10 per cent of the road construction and maintenance budgets for road safety management. The conference also called for the creation of road safety awareness at all levels, development of tools and systems for driver training and stricter licensing process, updating of road design and traffic engineering standards, and the development of new standards and implementation of scientific traffic management and road safety audits.

It's a tall order but all these are issues that need to be urgently addressed if India wants to have any chance of taming its killer roads. ■